CHAPTER 12

INSPIRED BY INDIA

Above all, the chanting makes me feel humble and privileged and, of course, obliged to score some runs.

It is difficult for me to understand how someone from a relatively small town in rural South Africa can be so fortunate and so favoured that when he walks out to bat, or simply takes guard, in almost any cricket ground in India, he can be greeted by tens of thousands of happy people chanting his initials.

A-B-D! A-B-D! A-B-D!

I am not arrogant, big-headed or self-important. I am simply grateful to God for giving me the talent to entertain people, for giving me the skill to hit a cricket ball in a way that excites people. I have wondered about these events and arrived at the conclusion that it remains His talent and His skill effectively being manifested through me. I genuinely feel so blessed to be following the path He has chosen for me.

As far as I can recall, the chant started in 2012, during the fifth season of the Indian Premier League (IPL). Royal Challengers Bangalore (RCB) were chasing 182 to beat Deccan Chargers at the Chinnaswamy Stadium and I walked out to bat when we were struggling at 106 for three, with six overs and one ball left. Our form had been inconsistent and we needed a win to stay alive in the competition, but the in-form Chargers appeared in control. With 39 runs needed from 18 balls,